490.LIFE · THE WHOLE STORY · LESSON 16 OF 26

A Kingdom Divided, Prophets Sent

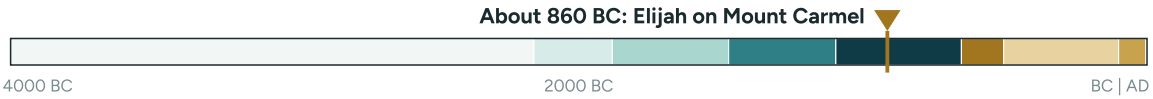
1 Kings 12; 17–19; 2 Kings 17



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YOU ARE HERE · LESSON 16



Introduction: Two Kingdoms and a Long Goodbye

Lesson 15 ended with a warning: because Solomon's heart turned away, the kingdom would be torn from his son. This lesson covers what happened next, about two hundred years of history packed into 1 and 2 Kings. One nation became two. Kings came and went, most of them bad. Idols spread. And over and over, God did something remarkable. He did not walk away. He sent prophets.

The prophets were God's messengers. They stood in front of kings and crowds and said, "Thus says the LORD." They warned, they wept, they called people home. The greatest of them in this period was Elijah, whose showdown on Mount Carmel is one of the most dramatic scenes in the whole Bible. But the story ends in tragedy. The northern kingdom would not listen, and in 722 BC it was wiped off the map.

On our timeline: the kingdom splits in 931 BC, Elijah confronts King Ahab around 860 BC, and the Assyrian Empire destroys the northern kingdom in 722 BC.

The Word: Elijah

> **1 Kings 18:39** *"And when all the people saw it, they fell on their faces and said, 'The LORD, he is God; the LORD, he is God.'"*

אֵלִיָּהוּ *(Eliyahu, "Elijah")*

"My God is the LORD"

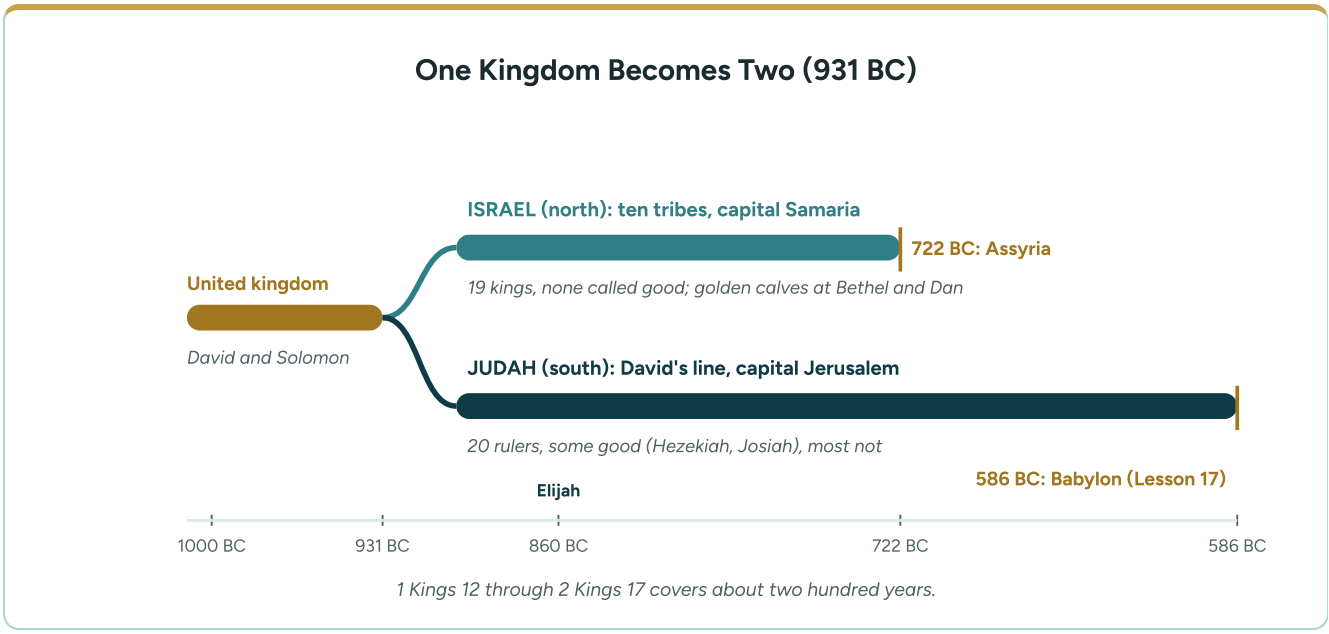
אֵלִי (Eli)	+	יָהוּ (yahu)
"my God"		*"the LORD"*
From *El*, the general Hebrew word for God.		A short form of God's personal name, revealed to Moses at the burning bush (Lesson 2).

Payoff: Elijah's name was his whole message. In a nation where people bowed to Baal, his very name said: my God is the LORD, and no one else. At the climax of his life, when fire fell from heaven, the whole crowd shouted the meaning of his name back as a confession of faith: "The LORD, he is God." That is the question this lesson puts to you. Who is your God?

Part One: A Kingdom Torn in Two

When Solomon died, his son Rehoboam went to be crowned. The northern tribes asked him to lighten the heavy taxes and forced labor his father had demanded. The old advisers told him to listen. His young friends told him to get tougher. He took his friends' advice: "My father made your yoke heavy, but I will add to your yoke. My father disciplined you with whips, but I will discipline you with scorpions" (1 Kings 12:14). The northern ten tribes walked out: "What portion do we have in David?… To your tents, O Israel!" (12:16).

From then on there were two kingdoms. The northern kingdom kept the name **Israel**, with its capital eventually at Samaria. The southern kingdom, made up mainly of the tribe of Judah, was called **Judah**, with its capital at Jerusalem and David's descendants on the throne.



The first northern king, Jeroboam, had a problem. The temple was in Jerusalem, in the southern kingdom. If his people kept going there to worship, he feared they would drift back to Judah. So he made two golden calves, put one at Bethel and one at Dan, and told the people, "You have gone up to Jerusalem long enough. Behold your gods, O Israel, who brought you up out of the land of Egypt" (12:28). Those were almost exactly the words Israel had said around the golden calf at Sinai (Ex. 32:4; Lesson 9). The northern kingdom started with idolatry, and it never recovered. Not one of its kings is called good. Judah had a mix of good and evil kings. A few, like Hezekiah, trusted the LORD deeply (2 Kings 18:5). But Judah drifted too.

Part Two: Fire on the Mountain

About sixty years after the split, the worst of Israel's kings took the throne. "Ahab the son of Omri did evil in the sight of the LORD, more than all who were before him" (16:30). He married Jezebel, a foreign princess who brought the worship of Baal, the Canaanite storm god, into Israel on a grand scale. Baal was supposed to bring the rain and make the crops grow.

So God sent a prophet to Ahab with a message aimed straight at Baal: "As the LORD, the God of Israel, lives, before whom I stand, there shall be neither dew nor rain these years, except by my word" (17:1). No rain, in the land of the rain god. Then Elijah disappeared. God hid him by a brook, where "the ravens brought him bread and meat in the morning, and bread and meat in the evening" (17:6). Later God sent him to a poor widow in Zarephath, a foreign town, where her flour and oil never ran out. Jesus would point to her centuries later as a sign that God's grace reaches outsiders (Luke 4:25–26).



"And the ravens brought him bread and meat in the morning, and bread and meat in the evening" (1 Kings 17:6).

After more than three years of drought, Elijah called for a showdown on Mount Carmel: 450 prophets of Baal against one prophet of the LORD. He put the question to the crowd first: "How long will you go limping between two different opinions? If the LORD is God, follow him; but if Baal, then follow him" (18:21). The people said nothing.

Each side would prepare a bull on an altar but light no fire. The god who answered by fire was God. Baal's prophets cried out from morning until noon. They danced. They cut themselves. Elijah mocked them: maybe Baal was busy, or asleep. Baal's prophets raved on until evening, "but there was no voice. No one answered; no one paid attention" (18:29).

Then Elijah rebuilt the LORD's broken altar with twelve stones, one for each tribe. He had the people soak the sacrifice and the wood with water, three times, until it filled the trench. And he prayed a simple prayer: "Answer me, O LORD, answer me, that this people may know that you, O LORD, are God, and that

you have turned their hearts back" (18:37). "Then the fire of the LORD fell and consumed the burnt offering and the wood and the stones and the dust, and licked up the water that was in the trench" (18:38). The people fell on their faces: "The LORD, he is God; the LORD, he is God" (18:39). Then Elijah had the prophets of Baal seized and put to death (18:40). That is hard to read. Israel was a nation under God's direct rule, and its covenant law treated a prophet who led the people to other gods as a capital traitor (Deut. 13:5). Like the conquest in Lesson 12, this belonged to Israel's unique place in history. It is not a pattern for the church. Christ's people fight false teaching with the truth, never with the sword (2 Cor. 10:4).

Part Three: The Prophet Who Wanted to Die

You would think Elijah would be on top of the world. Instead, when Jezebel swore to kill him, he ran for his life, sat down under a tree in the desert, and prayed to die: "It is enough; now, O LORD, take away my life, for I am no better than my fathers" (19:4).

Look at how God treated his worn-out servant. No lecture. He let him sleep. He sent an angel with food and water, twice. Then he led him to Mount Horeb, also called Sinai, the mountain where God gave Moses the law (Lesson 9). There a great wind tore the mountains, "but the LORD was not in the wind." An earthquake, "but the LORD was not in the earthquake." A fire, "but the LORD was not in the fire. And after the fire the sound of a low whisper" (19:11–12). God came to Elijah gently.

Elijah thought he was the only faithful person left. God told him he was wrong: "I will leave seven thousand in Israel, all the knees that have not bowed to Baal" (19:18). Paul would later point to this verse and say that God always keeps a people for himself: "a remnant, chosen by grace" (Rom. 11:5). If you feel alone in your faith, you are not. And if you are exhausted and discouraged, God is not finished with you. He fed his prophet, gave him rest, spoke to him, and gave him a friend, Elisha, to carry on the work. If you have ever prayed Elijah's prayer, please tell someone today: a pastor, a friend, or a doctor. In the U.S. you can call or text 988. God cared for Elijah through ordinary means like food, sleep, and a friend, and he still does.

Part Four: Prophets Sent, Prophets Ignored

Elijah was the first of many. Over the next century and a half, God sent prophet after prophet. Some of their words are recorded in the books that bear their names.

Prophets God Sent (Some Highlights)

Elijah *about 860 BC*	**to Israel**	"If the LORD is God, follow him" (1 Kings 18:21)
Elisha *about 850 BC*	**to Israel**	Miracles of mercy, even for a foreign general (2 Kings 5)
Jonah *about 780 BC*	**to Nineveh**	God's mercy reaches Israel's enemies (Jonah 4:2)
Amos *about 760 BC*	**to Israel**	"Let justice roll down like waters" (Amos 5:24)
Hosea *about 750 BC*	**to Israel**	"How can I give you up, O Ephraim?" (Hos. 11:8)
Isaiah *about 740 BC*	**to Judah**	"Holy, holy, holy is the LORD of hosts" (Isa. 6:3)

"The LORD warned Israel and Judah by every prophet and every seer" (2 Kings 17:13).

Amos was a shepherd and fig grower from Judah whom God sent north to say that religion without justice disgusts God: "let justice roll down like waters, and righteousness like an ever-flowing stream" (Amos 5:24). **Hosea** was told to marry an unfaithful wife and keep loving her, a living picture of God's love for unfaithful Israel. Through him God cried out, "How can I give you up, O Ephraim? How can I hand you over, O Israel?… My heart recoils within me; my compassion grows warm and tender" (Hos. 11:8). **Jonah** was sent to Nineveh, a great city of Assyria, Israel's greatest enemy, and when the city repented, God spared it, to Jonah's disgust. In the south, **Isaiah** saw the Lord in the temple and heard the seraphim cry, "Holy, holy, holy" (Isa. 6:3).

The message was always the same: turn back. The writer of Kings sums it up: "Yet the LORD warned Israel and Judah by every prophet and every seer, saying, 'Turn from your evil ways and keep my commandments…' But they would not listen, but were stubborn, as their fathers had been, who did not believe in the LORD their God" (2 Kings 17:13–14).

And so the end came. In 722 BC, after a three-year siege, "the king of Assyria captured Samaria, and he carried the Israelites away to Assyria" (17:6). The Assyrians scattered the northern tribes across their empire and brought in foreigners to resettle the land (17:24). Their descendants became the Samaritans you meet in the Gospels. The northern kingdom of Israel was gone. Only Judah remained, and Judah had been watching. The next lesson will show whether it learned anything.



"The king of Assyria captured Samaria, and he carried the Israelites away to Assyria" (2 Kings 17:6).

THREAD WATCH

THE LAMB When Isaiah saw the Lord, he cried out, "Woe is me! For I am lost; for I am a man of unclean lips" (Isa. 6:5). A seraph took a burning coal from the altar, the place of sacrifice, and touched his mouth: "your guilt is taken away, and your sin atoned for" (6:7). Forgiveness came from the altar. Isaiah would go on to describe a Servant who would go "like a lamb that is led to the slaughter" (Isa. 53:7). We will meet him again.

GOD WITH HIS PEOPLE Even as Israel abandoned him, God kept coming to them through his prophets, and he kept a remnant who had not bowed to Baal. God never stopped pursuing his people. That is why the prophets were sent at all.

The Turn: Finally He Sent His Son

Jesus once told a story about a man who planted a vineyard and leased it to tenants. At harvest he sent servants to collect his share, and the tenants beat one, killed another, and stoned a third. He sent more servants, and they did the same. "Finally he sent his son to them, saying, 'They will respect my son'" (Matt. 21:37). But they killed him too. The religious leaders knew he was talking about them (Matt. 21:45). The servants were the prophets. And the son was Jesus himself.

"Long ago, at many times and in many ways, God spoke to our fathers by the prophets, but in these last days he has spoken to us by his Son" (Heb. 1:1–2). The prophets said, "Thus says the LORD." Jesus said, "Truly, I say to you." He did not only bring God's word; he is the Word (John 1:1). He is the final Prophet, who reveals to us by his Word and Spirit the will of God for our salvation (Westminster Shorter Catechism 24). And Elijah himself appeared with Moses on the mountain of transfiguration, talking with Jesus (Matt. 17:3), the Law and the Prophets standing beside the One they had pointed to.

The last book of the Old Testament promised, "Behold, I will send you Elijah the prophet before the great and awesome day of the LORD comes" (Mal. 4:5). Jesus said that promise came true in John the Baptist (Matt. 11:14). John was not Elijah come back to life (John 1:21). He came "in the spirit and power of Elijah" to prepare the way (Luke 1:17). And when Jesus came, he was even greater than Elijah. Elijah called down fire on a sacrifice. Once, when his disciples wanted to call down fire on a village that rejected him, Jesus "turned and rebuked them" (Luke 9:54–55). He had not come to bring the fire down on sinners. He had come to take it himself. On the cross, the judgment that fell on Carmel's altar fell on him.

Elijah's question still stands, and it is for you: "How long will you go limping between two different opinions? If the LORD is God, follow him" (1 Kings 18:21). God has spoken by his Son, and his Son took the fire for sinners. The Lord is "patient toward you, not wishing that any should perish, but that all should reach repentance" (2 Pet. 3:9). Do not stop your ears the way the northern kingdom did. Turn from your idols, trust Jesus today, and say with the people on the mountain, "The LORD, he is God."

Living It: Six Practices for This Week

1 **Read Carmel.** Read 1 Kings 18:17–39 aloud. Notice how simple Elijah's prayer is compared to the prophets of Baal.

2 **Name your Baal.** Baal promised rain and crops: security and success. What do you look to for those things instead of God?

3 **Stop limping.** Where are you trying to keep one foot in each world? Ask God for grace to let go of one divided loyalty this week, and trust him with what you let go.

4 **Rest and eat.** If you are worn out like Elijah, take God's care seriously: sleep, eat, and spend quiet time listening for his voice in Scripture.

5 **Find the seven thousand.** You are not alone. Reach out to one other believer this week for encouragement and prayer.

6 **Memorize Hebrews 1:1–2.** "Long ago, at many times and in many ways, God spoke to our fathers by the prophets, but in these last days he has spoken to us by his Son."

Before Lesson 17: *Read 2 Kings 25, Jeremiah 29:1–14, and Daniel 1 and 6. Lesson 17 follows Judah into exile in Babylon, when the temple falls.*

For Discussion

1. Rehoboam listened to the advice that flattered his pride. Where are you tempted to listen to voices that tell you what you want to hear?
2. Jeroboam made idols to keep his people from going to Jerusalem. What "convenient" substitutes for God do people create today?
3. Baal was the god of rain, crops, and success. Why was the drought such a direct challenge to him? What do people trust for security today?

4. Elijah asked, “How long will you go limping between two different opinions?” Where are you limping?
5. Right after his greatest victory, Elijah wanted to die. What does God’s gentle care for him teach you about seasons of deep discouragement?
6. God sent prophet after prophet, and Israel would not listen. Why is it so hard to hear warnings?
7. Jesus told the story of the vineyard owner who finally sent his son. What does that story say about God’s patience and about who Jesus is?
8. Hebrews says God once spoke by the prophets but now has spoken by his Son. What changes if Jesus is God’s final word to you?

Sources & For Further Study

- On the dates of the divided kingdom: Edwin R. Thiele, *The Mysterious Numbers of the Hebrew Kings*; Eugene H. Merrill, *Kingdom of Priests*.
- On Baal and the Carmel contest: Dale Ralph Davis, *1 Kings: The Wisdom and the Folly*; Iain W. Provan, *1 and 2 Kings* (Understanding the Bible Commentary).
- For further reading: O. Palmer Robertson, *The Christ of the Prophets*; Westminster Shorter Catechism 24 (Christ’s office as a prophet).



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